

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Pharmacy Technician English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Pharmacy technicians and pharmacy support staff.

All patients, orders, amounts, times, and incidents are fictional language-practice examples, not medication, insurance, legal, dispensing, or technical training. Duties and supervision vary by jurisdiction and workplace. Pharmacists and other qualified professionals make clinical and regulated decisions. These exercises do not authorize dispensing, transfers, substitutions, handling methods, or changes to medication instructions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Prescription intake without assumptions

Identify an unclear prescription detail and explain who can clarify it.

02 Insurance claims in plain English

Distinguish a coverage review, a claim response, and a patient's payment.

03 Refill requests and response windows

Separate the request sent, the response pending, and the next contact.

04 Stock enquiries and delivery estimates

Report stock and delivery evidence without turning an estimate into a promise.

05 Pickup questions and pharmacist consultations

Transfer a label question without giving medication advice.

06 Private collection and contact preferences

Decline an unverified disclosure and offer a specific way to check collection arrangements.

07 Precise inventory and quality queries

Ask for review of a concrete stock discrepancy without guessing its consequences.

08 Corrected messages and shift handoffs

Correct an inaccurate status and make the next contact accountable.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Prescription intake without assumptions

Identify an unclear prescription detail and explain who can clarify it.

CASE

An order's strength field is unclear. The patient remembers a blue label and says their prescriber usually orders the same thing. The technician cannot select a strength. Pharmacist Maya can take the clarification; no completion time is known.

Teach this move

Name the exact field that needs checking. Attribute remembered information to the patient without treating it as a verified current order. 'Awaiting clarification' describes a status, not a cancellation.

Vocabulary to check: prescription, patient profile, prescriber, strength.

Model response

The current prescription's strength field is unclear. Your memory of the blue label gives us some background, but it does not confirm this order. Maya, our pharmacist, can handle the clarification. For now, the order is awaiting review; it has not been cancelled, and I cannot give you a collection time yet.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised statement identifies both the source of the information and its limit.

Second-round challenge

Ask whether awaiting clarification means the prescription has been cancelled.

Language-check answers

1. C - strength Correct. Strength describes the ingredient amount per unit.
2. C - recalled Correct. Recalled attributes the information to memory.

05 • Conversations

1. The blue label does not settle the strength - Fictional counter exchange using the lesson case; pharmacist Maya is available.
2. One letter apart - Fictional intake desk; two similar names appear, and neither record has been changed.

3. Receipt before readiness - Fictional patient shows a received notification; the live record says pharmacist review pending.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A change discussed but not received

A patient remembers the prescriber discussing a different strength yesterday. The received order does not show that change. Pharmacist Maya is available; nobody has confirmed whether a revised order was sent.

Role A: Technician: identify the discrepancy without selecting either strength.

Role B: Patient: you remember a discussion, not the exact instruction or whether a new order was issued.

Possible opening: The prescriber said something would change, but this looks like my previous order.

Success checks

- Attribute the discussion to the patient's account.
- Name the difference between that account and the received order.
- Pass the question to Maya without choosing a strength or promising completion.

Add a complication: The patient asks you to describe the remembered discussion as a confirmed new prescription.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Insurance claims in plain English

Distinguish a coverage review, a claim response, and a patient's payment.

CASE

The claim response says prior authorization required. No plan decision or accepted claim has arrived. The patient thinks this is a permanent exclusion. Billing colleague Inez has accepted the status query and can explain the request route.

Teach this move

Use one plain-English explanation before returning to the technical term. 'Required' does not mean 'approved.' An authorization decision and the amount on a processed claim answer different questions.

Vocabulary to check: claim rejection, prior authorization, formulary, copayment.

Model response

This response says prior authorization is required. That is a request for the plan's review, not the final coverage decision. We have neither an approval decision nor an accepted claim yet. Inez is handling the status query and can explain how the request proceeds; I cannot promise coverage or a final copayment.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision describes the actual message rather than making a permanent prediction.

Second-round challenge

Ask whether receiving an approval would automatically make the prescription free.

Language-check answers

1. B - coverage review requirement Correct. This explains the approval requirement in everyday language.
2. B - although Correct. Although contrasts the confirmed approval with an unresolved claim.

05 • Conversations

1. A requirement, not a final refusal - Fictional pharmacy counter using the prior-authorization case.
2. A friend's ten-dollar payment - Fictional accepted claim shows a twenty-dollar copayment; the patient mentions a friend's different plan.

3. The number on an old card - Fictional billing call: claim rejected because member information needs verification; acceptance is not guaranteed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Approval without a payment amount

An authorization approval has arrived. The final claim has not been processed. Last month's patient share was zero, but today's amount is unknown. Inez handles payment queries.

Role A: Technician: explain what the approval establishes and what remains open.

Role B: Patient: you need to know whether to bring money when collecting.

Possible opening: Last month was free, and now you have approval, so today's supply is free too?

Success checks

- Separate listing, authorization, and processed payment.
- Avoid carrying forward last month's amount.
- Identify Inez as the contact for the remaining claim question.

Add a complication: The patient confuses a formulary listing with a confirmed zero copayment.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Refill requests and response windows

Separate the request sent, the response pending, and the next contact.

CASE

The record shows no refills remaining. A renewal request was sent at 09:00 and has no response at 11:00. Technician Jo can call the patient between 15:00 and 16:00. No supply or prescriber response time is confirmed.

Teach this move

Use 'sent at' for a completed action and 'awaiting' for the outstanding response. A patient's travel deadline explains their concern but does not create a dispensing authorization.

Vocabulary to check: refill, renewal request, refills remaining, callback window.

Model response

There are no refills remaining on this prescription. We sent a renewal request at nine, but no response is recorded as of eleven. I can call between three and four with the status. That is a callback window, not confirmation that the prescriber will respond or that a supply will be ready then.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The call can be arranged even though the prescription outcome is unknown.

Second-round challenge

Ask whether the pharmacy's message to the prescriber counts as the prescriber's permission.

Language-check answers

1. A - sent Correct. Sent identifies the completed outgoing request.
2. A - between Correct. Between pairs with and to specify the window.

05 • Conversations

1. The nine o'clock request - Fictional refill call using the lesson case.
2. Two requests, one record - Fictional duplicate web and telephone refill requests; both refer to the same prescription.

3. A trip is not a refill allowance - Fictional patient leaves Friday; record review is pending and pharmacist Ravi is available.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A missed callback

Jo agreed to call yesterday between three and four but did not. No renewal response has arrived. Jo can provide a new status call today at noon; the pharmacist can address medication concerns now.

Role A: Technician: acknowledge the missed contact and give the current status.

Role B: Patient: you stayed home expecting the call and want a reliable next contact.

Possible opening: I waited all afternoon yesterday; was the prescription ready and nobody told me?

Success checks

- Apologize for the missed callback specifically.
- Keep approval and readiness unconfirmed.
- Agree the noon contact and offer the pharmacist for medication questions.

Add a complication: The patient interprets an apology as confirmation that approval has arrived.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Stock enquiries and delivery estimates

Report stock and delivery evidence without turning an estimate into a promise.

CASE

The pharmacy has no stock for a patient's order. The wholesaler estimates Wednesday delivery, but shipment is not confirmed. Technician Lee can check the supplier update Tuesday at 16:00. The pharmacist handles questions about alternatives.

Teach this move

A supplier's stock, its shipment, the pharmacy's receipt, and a patient's collection are separate events. State which event the date refers to. Keep medicine-choice questions with the pharmacist.

Vocabulary to check: backorder, wholesaler, allocation, estimated arrival.

Model response

Our pharmacy has no stock for this order today. The wholesaler estimates Wednesday delivery, but has not confirmed shipment, so Wednesday is not a collection promise. Lee will check the supplier update Tuesday at four. If you need to discuss alternatives or the effect of waiting, I can connect you with the pharmacist.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The correction identifies both the source and the uncertain event.

Second-round challenge

Ask whether another branch's online stock display guarantees that branch can supply your prescription.

Language-check answers

1. D - estimated arrival Correct. Estimated arrival is a prediction of delivery.
2. D - allocation Correct. Allocation is the quantity assigned.

05 • Conversations

1. Wednesday is an estimate - Fictional stock enquiry using the lesson case.

2. Six assigned from ten requested - Fictional pharmacy supply call about a fictional nonclinical stock order; no patient allocation decisions.

3. The branch display is not a reservation - Fictional customer sees online stock at another branch; no availability has been checked directly.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A delivered parcel, no item confirmation

A wholesaler parcel arrived at 10:00, but the stock team has not confirmed whether it includes item P7. A patient has heard 'the delivery arrived.' Stock lead Lee can check the receipt list now.

Role A: Technician: explain the distinction between a parcel and a specific item.

Role B: Patient: you believe P7 must be inside and want a collection promise.

Possible opening: The delivery van just left, so mine is definitely here now, isn't it?

Success checks

- Acknowledge the parcel's arrival.
- Keep P7's receipt and prescription readiness separate.
- Request Lee's item-level confirmation without recommending an alternative medicine.

Add a complication: The wholesaler's earlier estimate mentioned P7 but no shipment list was confirmed.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Pickup questions and pharmacist consultations

Transfer a label question without giving medication advice.

CASE

At pickup, patient Arden asks what an auxiliary label means. The technician can identify the label but cannot interpret the instruction. Pharmacist Ravi is available at the consultation counter and accepts the question. No instructions are changed.

Teach this move

Quote or identify the unclear wording rather than guessing what the patient means. Name the pharmacist who has accepted the conversation. Recognizing a dosage form is not permission to substitute it.

Vocabulary to check: dispensing status, counseling, auxiliary label, dosage form.

Model response

Ravi, Arden has a question about the wording on this auxiliary label before collection. I have not interpreted it or changed any instructions. Could you take that question at the consultation counter? Arden, Ravi will explain the label with you; I will keep the pickup conversation separate from that medication guidance.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. This preserves the question instead of dismissing it.

Second-round challenge

Ask the technician to give a quick answer because the queue is growing.

Language-check answers

1. D - dosage form Correct. Tablet and liquid are physical forms.
2. A - explain Correct. Explain addresses the meaning of the wording.

05 • Conversations

1. A question before collection - Fictional pickup counter using the label-handoff case.

2. Tablet is not a strength - Fictional patient uses the word strength when asking about tablet versus liquid.
3. Two bags, two statuses - Fictional patient has one prescription ready and another awaiting pharmacist review.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An unopened leaflet question

Patient Kim has not collected a prescription and wants a phrase in its information leaflet explained. Pharmacist Ravi is free in five minutes. The technician cannot interpret the phrase; no medicine problem is reported.

Role A: Technician: identify the question and arrange the consultation.

Role B: Patient: ask whether the leaflet wording changes the main label instructions.

Possible opening: This leaflet uses different words from the label. Which should I follow?

Success checks

- Preserve both texts as the subject of the question.
- Avoid selecting or changing instructions.
- State the five-minute consultation availability without diagnosing a conflict.

Add a complication: Kim asks you to reconcile the two texts while Ravi finishes another consultation.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Private collection and contact preferences

Decline an unverified disclosure and offer a specific way to check collection arrangements.

CASE

A person says they are collecting for their neighbor. Their collection authority has not been verified. They ask the technician to read out the neighbor's medicines to identify the right package. Lead pharmacist Maya can review the collection question privately.

Teach this move

Separate a person's helpful intention from established authority. Explain the information boundary without labeling the visitor dishonest. Do not teach a universal list of documents or legal permissions.

Vocabulary to check: authorized representative, confidentiality, identity verification, contact preference.

Model response

I can help with the collection enquiry, but I cannot read out someone else's medicine details while their collection arrangements are unverified. Maya can review the required checks with you privately. Please tell her that you are here on your neighbor's behalf; I have not yet confirmed which information or package can be released.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision avoids treating one familiar detail as sufficient authority.

Second-round challenge

Say that you have collected before and ask why today's enquiry needs checking.

Language-check answers

1. A - authority Correct. Authority concerns permission to collect for someone.
2. B - neutral Correct. Neutral wording avoids the unnecessary medicine detail.

05 • Conversations

1. Collecting for a neighbor - Fictional counter enquiry using the lesson privacy case.

2. A shared telephone - Fictional patient updates contact preferences; a shared home telephone should receive neutral messages only.
3. A louder voice would not help - Fictional patient requests a quieter counter instead of having details repeated publicly.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A changed contact number

A patient says the number on their profile belongs to an old employer. No new number has been verified. They can review contact information at the private counter now; no contact attempt has been made today.

Role A: Technician: acknowledge the outdated information and arrange its review.

Role B: Patient: ask whether the pharmacy already contacted the old employer today.

Possible opening: Please don't use that number; I no longer work there.

Success checks

- State that no contact attempt has been made today.
- Avoid claiming what happened on other dates.
- Confirm the contact update through the private review.

Add a complication: The patient assumes an old number proves that private information was disclosed today.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Precise inventory and quality queries

Ask for review of a concrete stock discrepancy without guessing its consequences.

CASE

A fictional recall notice names lot AB41. The delivery record shows AB14, but the stock label has not been checked against the notice. Lead pharmacist Maya handles recall assessment. No affected status, patient exposure, or release decision has been established.

Teach this move

Similar identifiers are not identical. State the observed record and the notice separately. This lesson practices reporting, not recall handling, storage methods, disposal, or product-release decisions.

Vocabulary to check: lot number, expiry date, recall notice, quarantined stock.

Model response

Maya, could you compare the stock's complete lot number with this recall notice? The notice lists AB41, while the delivery record says AB14. I have not established whether the stock is affected. Please confirm who will assess the discrepancy and its release status; I will not describe these similar numbers as a match.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. An exact comparison replaces a visual impression.

Second-round challenge

Ask whether the similar numbers prove a patient received affected stock.

Language-check answers

1. A - lot number Correct. The lot number identifies the manufacturing batch.
2. A - discrepancy Correct. A discrepancy is the difference needing review.

05 • Conversations

1. AB41 or AB14 - Fictional stock-room communication using the recall-identifier case; no handling procedure is enacted.

2. A damaged carton - Fictional visible outer-carton damage is reported; contents and product suitability have not been assessed.

3. A count with a defined scope - Fictional inventory query: shelf count is twelve, system shows fourteen; no cause established.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Stock present but unavailable

The screen shows eight units physically present, all marked quarantined pending pharmacist assessment. A colleague asks whether eight means eight available for a patient order. No release decision exists.

Role A: Technician: explain the difference between physical count and available inventory.

Role B: Colleague: you saw only the total and need a clear availability message.

Possible opening: There are eight on the screen, so can I say we have stock available?

Success checks

- State both quantity and quarantine status.
- Avoid making a product-quality conclusion.
- Refer the release-status question to the pharmacist.

Add a complication: The colleague treats quarantined as another shelf location with no effect on availability.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Corrected messages and shift handoffs

Correct an inaccurate status and make the next contact accountable.

CASE

At 14:00 technician Jo told a patient the order was ready, misreading a queue entry. At 14:10 Jo confirms pharmacist review remains pending. The patient has started travelling. Jo owns a correction call now and a status call at 16:00; no collection time is known.

Teach this move

An apology should identify the actual mistake. State the verified correction, acknowledge its effect, and name who owns the next call. An incident record is not proof that follow-up has occurred.

Vocabulary to check: near miss, incident report, audit trail, outstanding task.

Model response

I'm sorry I told you the order was ready at two. I misread the queue entry; pharmacist review is still pending, so that pickup message was incorrect. I understand you have already started travelling. I'll correct the record and call with the status at four, but I cannot confirm a collection time yet.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised apology owns the wording and supplies a usable correction.

Second-round challenge

Ask for a guaranteed collection time to make up for the inconvenience.

Language-check answers

1. A - I incorrectly Correct. It directly owns the inaccurate statement.
2. D - accept Correct. Accept makes ownership explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Correcting a premature pickup call - Fictional telephone correction using the lesson case.

2. A named owner at shift change - Fictional handoff: technician Jo hands an agreed callback to incoming technician Lee.

3. Caught before the label left the desk - Fictional training discussion: a wrong-profile draft label was noticed before use; nothing was supplied.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A sent message without acceptance

Jo sent Lee a message asking for a 15:00 callback, but Lee has not acknowledged it and is unavailable. Jo remains on duty until 14:30; shift lead Maya can allocate the call. No prescription outcome is confirmed.

Role A: Jo: explain why the callback still lacks an accepted owner.

Role B: Maya: ask about the agreed time and arrange ownership without marking the call completed.

Possible opening: The message went to Lee, but nobody has accepted the three o'clock call yet.

Success checks

- Distinguish message delivery from task acceptance.
- State the existing callback time.
- Obtain an explicit owner while keeping the contact task open.

Add a complication: A colleague says a sent message is enough to close the task.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All patients, orders, amounts, times, and incidents are fictional language-practice examples, not medication, insurance, legal, dispensing, or technical training. Duties and supervision vary by jurisdiction and workplace. Pharmacists and other qualified professionals make clinical and regulated decisions. These exercises do not authorize dispensing, transfers, substitutions, handling methods, or changes to medication instructions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: Pharmacy Technicians

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/healthcare/pharmacy-technicians.htm>

Pharmacy Technician Certification Board: Certified Pharmacy Technician

<https://ptcb.org/credentials/certification/certified-pharmacy-technician/>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.